Writing magnanimously about the weather and the fruit, Abu'l Fazl mentioned that 'musk melons are to be had throughout the whole year', a detail that would have delighted Akbar's grandfather, Babur. 'When the season is over, they are imported from Kashmir and from Kabul, Badakhshan and Turkestan. Snow is brought down every year from the northern mountains.' The availability of snow and ice was one of the great luxuries of the court at Lahore. These were transported from the mountains north of Lahore, and brought to the capital every day by boats, carriages, and runners. The most profitable way was to bring down the ice by river, in boats manned by four oarsmen. When carriages were used, the journey was accomplished in fourteen stages, with horses changed at each stage. A total of 50 to 120 kilograms of ice and snow arrived every day, depending on the season. While noblemen were able to afford ice all the year round, the lower ranks only bought it in the hot summers.

As the empire had expanded dramatically in the first thirty years of Akbar's rule, bringing into the Mughal fold the rich provinces of Gujarat and Bengal, had gained it access to the sea, which helped it economically. In the kar khanas that were promoted enthusiastically, 'Akbar promoted textile manufacture for foreign markets, building roads that connected Mughal weavers' workshops to seaports and abolishing inland tolls and duties'. The goods were sent to China, Arabia, Abyssinia*, and Europe; the Europeans were able to pay for the precious silks and cottons with silver mined in South America and the cities of the empire grew prosperous.

Placed along the major route leading to Central Asia, Lahore was clearly therefore already a thrumming city by the time Akbar decided to stop here instead of moving back to Fatehpur Sikri. The Padshah rebuilt the fort of the city which became known as the Shahi Qila. It included a rampart with twelve gates, an audience hall, personal living quarters, and a zenana. It is likely that Akbar's court miniaturists and artists decorated the Padshah's quarters and the zenana. There would, however, be no inferno of building as there had been in Fatehpur Sikri. No layered palaces, or inscrutable minars, or intimidating expanses of stone. Akbar's great building days were over and it would be royal family members, and the courtiers of the empire, who would take on the task of architectural patronage.

'Throughout Akbar's reign,' writes urban studies scholar William Glover, 'court nobles were encouraged to build palaces, gardens, and